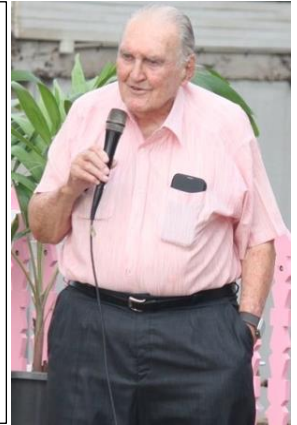




The Garamut "The message sender"

Ps Barry Reflections *from 'The WORD'!* **For PRAYER,** **PROCLAMATION &** **PERSONAL PROGRESS**

Bethel Global Missions
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OUR MESSAGE: **GOD WAS IN THIS PLACE** **I KNEW IT NOT** **I STUMBLED INTO** **ENTRANCE TO HEAVEN**

Genesis 28:11-22

11 That night, when he stopped to camp at sundown, he found a rock for a headrest and lay down to sleep,
12 and dreamed that a staircase reached from earth to heaven, and he saw the angels of God going up and down upon it.

13 At the top of the stairs stood the Lord. "I am Jehovah," he said, "the God of Abraham, and of your father, Isaac. The ground you are lying on is yours! I will give it to you and to your descendants.

14 For you will have descendants as many as dust! They will cover the land from east to west and from north to south; and all the nations of the earth will be blessed through you and your descendants.

15 What's more, I am with you, and will protect you wherever you go, and will bring you back safely to this land; I will be with you constantly until I have finished giving you all I am promising."

16-17 Then Jacob woke up. "God lives here!" he exclaimed in terror. "I've stumbled into his home! This is the awesome entrance to heaven!"

18 The next morning he got up very early and set his stone headrest upright as a memorial pillar, and poured olive oil over it.

19 He named the place Bethel ("House of God"), though the previous name of the nearest village was Luz. TLB

Genesis 28:16 Jacob said, ... **"Surely the Lord is in this place, and I did not know it."** NKJV

Then Jacob woke up. **"God lives here!" he exclaimed in terror. "I've stumbled into his home! This is the awesome entrance to heaven!"** The Living Bible

Genesis 28:16-17

Summary of events

In Genesis 28, Jacob was a vulnerable fugitive. Fleeing for his life after deceiving his father (Isaac) and angering his brother (Esau), he left home with only a staff. Exhausted, alone, and far from the Promised Land, he camped in the wilderness, sleeping with his head on a stone.

While sleeping at this vulnerable low point, Jacob had a vision (dream) of a massive stairway (often referred to as a "ladder") stretching between earth and heaven, with angels ascending and descending.

In waking up in awe and fear, Jacob realized he was in the presence of the divine. He renamed the location *Bethel* (meaning "House of God"), set up his stone pillow as a memorial pillar, poured oil on it, and made a vow to God.

Upon waking up, Jacob was struck by a powerful sense of holy awe. **BECAUSE HE HAD PREVIOUSLY TREATED THE LOCATION AS JUST AN ORDINARY, DESOLATE REST STOP**, the sudden realization of God's personal intervention prompted him to exclaim, **"God lives here!" he exclaimed in terror. "I've stumbled into his home! This is the awesome entrance to heaven!"** TLB Genesis 28:16-17

I WOULD LIKE TO REFLECT ON THIS ENCOUNTER OF JACOB WITH GOD THAT IT WAS NOT PLANNED, NO PREWARNING THAT HE WOULD MEET ANGELS' HEAVEN AND GOD THAT HE STUMBLED INTO THE HOUSE WHERE THE PRESENCE OF GOD WAS.

NOTE THIS STATEMENT - He stumbled into this meeting with God.

HAS THIS KIND OF THING EVER HAPPENED TO YOU?

Where through unexpected events or circumstances you have found yourself in a house, home, church where God's presence was there and you did not know it beforehand.

MY PERSONAL TESTIMONY

This happened to me in November 1958 when I attended a meeting as a result a promised, I made to one of my employee's persistent invitations where a Christian teacher was giving a series of lectures.

With no thoughts about God or religion, I found myself inside old, corrugated Iron- roofed army building called a "Nissan hut" and in my unregenerate state, I encountered the AWESOME ENTRANCE TO HEAVEN - God and his saving, transforming power in my life.

SO, IN A WAY – I "STUMBLED (ACCIDENTALLY & UNEXPECTEDLY) INTO A PLACE WHERE GOD'S PRESENCE WAS – AND DID NOT KNOW IT NOT.

IT WAS MY AWESOME ENTRANCE TO HEAVEN

"God lives here!" he exclaimed in terror. "I've stumbled into his home! This is the awesome entrance to heaven!"

THERE ARE A NUMBER OF PEOPLE IN SCRIPTURE THAT STUMBLED INTO HOLY MOMENTS ENTIRELY BY ACCIDENT OR THROUGH EVERYDAY CIRCUMSTANCES, ONLY TO SUDDENLY REALIZE THEY WERE IN THE PROFOUND PRESENCE OF GOD. THESE UNEXPECTED ENCOUNTERS CHANGED THEIR LIVES AND REDIRECTED THEIR DESTINIES.

Examples:

MOSES (Exodus 3:1-5): Moses was simply doing his daily job of tending sheep when his curiosity caused him to turn aside from his daily duties to examine an ordinary bush that was mysteriously burning but was not being consumed by the flames. It was only then that they encountered the presence of God in the bush and his speaking to Moses.

SAUL, later the Apostle Paul (Acts 9:1-9): Saul was traveling to Damascus with the sole intention of arresting and persecuting Christians. He had no intention of worshiping or finding God. Yet, he accidentally entered into the blinding presence of the resurrected Christ, who struck him to the ground and radically changed his life forever. EACH OF THESE MEN EXPERIENCED A HOLY INTERRUPTION. THEIR STORIES DEMONSTRATE THAT GOD'S PRESENCE CAN BREAK INTO EVEN THE MOST ORDINARY, UNEXPECTED, OR UNINTENDED MOMENTS.

THIS IS ALSO WHAT HAPPENED TO CHARLES HADDON SPURGEON

The most famous historical example is Charles Haddon Spurgeon, widely known as "The Prince of Preachers". On January 6, 1850, the 15-year-old Spurgeon was walking to his usual church in Colchester, England, when a severe snowstorm blocked his route. Seeking shelter, he wandered into a small Primitive Methodist Chapel on Artillery Street.

The scheduled pastor was snowed in, so a substitute—an uneducated layman—stepped in to preach. Using the text from Isaiah 45:22 ("Look unto me, and be ye saved"), the layman caught Spurgeon's attention, pointed directly at him, and shouted: *"Young man, look to Jesus Christ! Look! Look! Look! You have nothing to do but to look and live!"*

This providential "accident" instantly brought Spurgeon to faith. He went on to become one of the most prolific and celebrated evangelical pastors in Christian history, eventually preaching to tens of millions of people in London and beyond.

Question:

WHAT ABOUT THE LIFE OF OTHERS?

HOW MANY PEOPLE DO WE KNOW OF THAT CAME TO CHRIST THROUGH EVENTS AND CIRCUMSTANCES THAT CAUSED THEM TO COME TO A HOUSE OR CHURCH WHERE GOD WAS THERE – AND THEY KNEW IT NOT. IN A SENSE THEIR ACTIONS WERE SIMILAR WHAT HAPPENED TO JACOB AT BETHEL. *"God lives here!" "I've stumbled into his home! This is the awesome entrance to heaven!"*

WHAT ABOUT YOUR OWN LIFE?

HAVE YOU EVER THOUGHT ABOUT THE EVENTS OF YOUR OWN LIFE AND WHAT LED YOU TO A HOME, A CHURCH, OR SOMEPLACE WHERE YOU DISCOVERED CHRIST WITHOUT PRIOR KNOWLEDGE THAT GOD WAS IN THAT PLACE?

THAT PATHWAY

MIGHT HAVE BEEN THROUGH AN INVITATION TO ATTEND A MEETING, OR IT MIGHT HAVE BEEN BECAUSE OF A CAR OR WORK ACCIDENT OR A BROKEN MARRIAGE, OR A DISAPPOINTING RELATIONSHIP, OR THE DEATH OF A LOVED ONE OR SOMEONE SHOWING YOU FORGIVENESS ACCEPTANCE AND AMAZING KINDNESS.

IN MY SINFUL STATE, WITH A HEART THAT HAD NO PLACE FOR GOD IN IT, I ACCIDENTALLY FOUND MYSELF ONE NIGHT IN A PLACE WHERE GOD WAS IN RESIDENCE AND I KNEW IT NOT. AND MY EXPERIENCE ECHOED THAT OF JACOB AS HE HAD HIS VISION/DREAM OF ANGELS ASCENDING AND DESCENDING TO HEAVEN AND SO THAT NIGHT I ALSO DISCOVERED - THE ENTRANCE TO HEAVEN AND UNEXPECTEDLY IN A PLACE WHERE GOD WAS AND I KNEW IT NOT *"God lives here!" "I've stumbled into his home! this is the awesome entrance to heaven!"*

LET US THANK GOD FOR HIS PROVIDENTIAL CARE OVER OUR LIVES IN BRINGING US TO HIMSELF.
Amen - Ps Barry